Chishti.' The shaikh then asked him what he would do if someone challenged the legacy of Hazrat Muinuddin. 'I would call such a person a kafir,' maintained Akbar stoutly, 'and kill him with my own hands.' Similarly, argued the shaikh, the Mahdi was his spiritual guide, equally mystical and equally benign. At some point in the discussions, which the shaikh would later transcribe himself in his cell, the ulema reacted to the shaikh's persuasive and charged message by saying, 'If we, the learned people in the Emperor's assembly, hear even a little of his words, we might imagine that he is right, for his words made an impression on our heart. For this reason, one must not permit fitnah [actions threatening the stability and power of a Muslim state]'. The ulema were unwavering in their condemnation of the shaikh who, in turn, refused one day to follow the sadr, Abd un-Nabi, in the midday prayer, accusing the ulema of being 'false men' who 'appear before the king, flatter him and his nobles, and accept his largesse'. These false men, he thundered, would never see God.

Shaikh Mustafa would remain more than a year at Akbar's court, infuriating the ulema and being carefully questioned by the Padshah. These discussions were only the beginning of an extraordinary series of religious and philosophical explorations by Akbar, a deeply personal search by the Padshah for a truth that reflected his growing maturity. Shaikh Mustafa's health, meanwhile, deteriorated rapidly and when Badauni went to visit him where he was staying at Abd al-Samad's house, the charismatic and dynamic preacher had become a frail and feeble man, suddenly old, and vomiting blood. Akbar eventually released him, allowing him to return to Gujarat but the shaikh never did reach Gujarat, dying en route, at Bayana in 1576.

In the midst of this curdle and churn, two men arrived at Akbar's court, childhood friends who were reunited at Fatehpur Sikri but whose trajectory at the Mughal court would torque in vastly different directions. Both men were troubled, searching for answers in Akbar's glittering new court into which men of worth and talent were being voraciously assimilated each day. The first to arrive, in 1574, was Badauni, now thirty-four years old, and scoured and bruised by personal tragedies. He had recently witnessed a terrible fire at Badaun, where 'many Hindus and Musulmans perished in the flames… carts filled with the charred remains were driven down to the river and none could tell who was a Moslem and who an infidel'.